

OPULENCE The store of designer Sabyasachi Mukherjee (top right), sprawled over 25,000 sq. ft, is adorned with over 100 chandeliers, 275 carpets, 3,000 books and 150 works of art layered among antique Tanjore paintings, rare lithographs and historical trinkets

ing off Horniman Circle. “I think when you truly know who you are, the aesthetic just follows. When I saw the heritage landmark building, I knew this was the perfect location... to capture the sensibility behind my stores, the spirit of Calcutta that is so beautifully embodied in the old homes and palaces of the city.”

Known for his grandeur and opulence, the designer has reimagined the store as a living museum of sorts—where the interiors have been transformed into an immersive retail experience that blends together Indian opulence, craftsmanship, and history. “I want people all over the world to experience our Indian heritage of design, art and luxury. I want them to feel how fine our fabrics are... how exquisite our hand embroideries are, and for them to also realise how wearable, luxurious and global it all is,” says the 49-year-old designer. Incidentally, Aditya Birla Fashion and Retail Ltd, part of the Aditya Birla Group, acquired a 51 per cent stake in the fashion house, which retails under the brand name Sabyasachi, in January 2021.

“The world has a terrible habit of pigeonholing designers to their geographies if they’re not from the western world, I want to challenge that narrative by owning my identity completely. It’s what I’ve always done. But from the customer’s point of view, you have to see and feel what we do to realise that. It’s why we went ahead with New York even in the midst of the pandemic and why I opened my largest store yet in Mumbai. With Mumbai, we grew out of our old store, and we’re growing into new markets—it’s as organic as it is strategic,” says Mukherjee who opened a store in New York in October last year. “India is no longer the backyard of global fashion, it’s time we lead from the front,” he adds.

At the Mumbai store, over 100 chandeliers, 275 carpets, 3,000 books, and 150 works of art created by the Sabyasachi Foundation are placed among antique Tanjore paintings, vintage photography and historical trinkets, some from his own collection. The space is lined with souk-sourced curiosity cabinets, modern interpretations of Persian Qajars, rare French Art Nouveau cabinets, Tang dynasty pottery and other antiques. It is adorned with wallpaper from the Sabyasachi for Nilaya collection by Asian Paints. “The biggest challenge with maximalism is that it never ends. It’s layer upon layer of art, antiques, crafts, and so on. You can’t just plug a blueprint in with a store like this. It unravels as it’s being layered,” he says.

The ground floor holds the Sabyasachi bridal collection. The first floor is dedicated to the brand’s largest showcase of jewellery in the world, housing fine, heritage

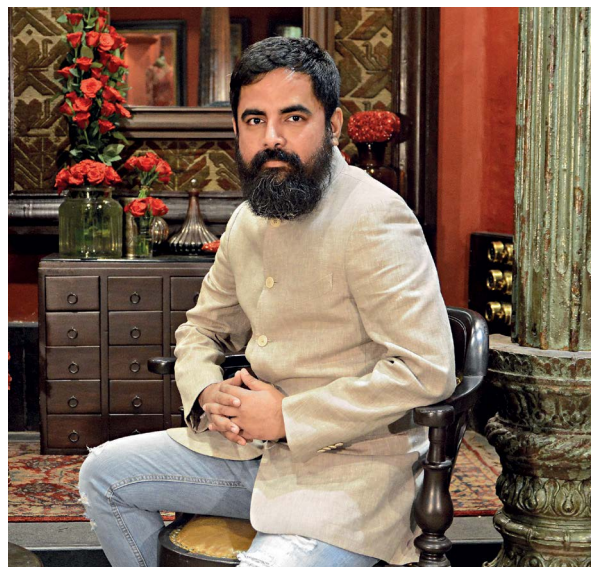


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and high jewellery collections. And the second floor is home to womenswear, menswear, the international collection, and Sabyasachi’s accessories.

Housed within is a micro-exhibit from the Sabyasachi archives currently showcasing couture from the Sabyasachi X Christian Louboutin collaboration from 2015 and 2016. There is also a tea room, where guests can savour some of his favourite blends. “There’s nothing like sipping on some long leaf Darjeeling in this quiet corner of the store,” says Mukherjee.

With the opening of the Mumbai flagship store, the total number of Sabyasachi stores in India goes up to four—Delhi, Kolkata, Mumbai and a jewellery store in Hyderabad. In addition, there is the New York store and an exclusive Sabyasachi Jewellery boutique in Dubai. **BT**

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